



United States
Attorney's Office
District of South Carolina



8 Charged in North Charleston Public Corruption Schemes, including 3 City Councilmen

Wednesday, February 26, 2025

For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, District of South
Carolina

CHARLESTON, S.C. — Eight people have been charged in federal court for a series of bribery, kickback, extortion, and money laundering schemes following a public corruption investigation in North Charleston. Three of the individuals charged are elected members of the North Charleston City Council.

Four individuals have been charged by Information and have agreed to plead guilty:

Jerome Sydney Heyward, 61, North Charleston City Councilmember;

Sandino Savalas Moses, 50, North Charleston City Councilmember;

Donavan Laval Moten, 46, founder of Core4Success Foundation; and

Aaron Charles-Lee Hicks, 37, resident of North Charleston.

A federal grand jury returned indictments against four others:

Mike A. Brown, 46, North Charleston City Council Member;

Hason Tatorian ("Tory") Fields, 51, a Goose Creek resident;

Rose Emily Lorenzo, 65, a North Carolina resident; and

Michelle Stent-Hilton, 56, a North Charleston resident.

Heyward is charged in three separate schemes with corruptly using his position as a North Charleston City Councilman to personally enrich himself through bribes, kickbacks, and extortion and to deprive the citizens and the government of North Charleston of their intangible right to the honest and faithful services of the North Charleston City Council. In the first scheme, Heyward extorted a businessman by

soliciting payments in exchange for his official action as a City Councilman. In the second scheme, Heyward conspired with Mike A. Brown and Aaron Hicks to solicit and accept bribes from Aaron Hicks—working on behalf of a company with business before North Charleston City Council—in exchange for his support of the rezoning of the Baker Hospital site. In the third scheme, Heyward conspired with Donavan Moten, Rose Lorenzo, and Michelle Stent-Hilton to embezzle funds belonging to North Charleston by soliciting and accepting kickbacks from non-profit organizations run by Moten and Stent-Hilton that received violence reduction grant funds from the City.

Heyward has agreed to plead guilty to: extortion under color of official right and using fear of economic harm; multiple counts of conspiracy to commit bribery with respect to programs receiving federal funds and honest services wire fraud; multiple counts of bribery with respect to programs receiving federal funds and honest services wire fraud; theft with respect to programs receiving federal funds; and multiple counts of money laundering. Heyward faces a maximum term of imprisonment of 20 years, a fine of \$500,000, and a term of supervised release of three years. Heyward has agreed to cooperate with federal, state, and local law enforcement agencies.

Mike A. Brown is charged with conspiring with Heyward and Hicks to commit bribery and honest services wire fraud. The indictment alleges that Mike A. Brown, while serving as a North Charleston City Councilmember, solicited and accepted bribes from Hicks—working on behalf of a company requesting the rezoning of the Baker Hospital site—in exchange for his support of the rezoning application. Mike A. Brown faces a maximum term of imprisonment of 20 years, a fine of \$250,000, and a term of supervised release of three years. He will be arraigned on these charges in March.

Aaron Hicks is charged with a conspiracy to pay bribes to Mike A. Brown and Jerome Heyward and a separate conspiracy with Hason Tatorian Fields to bribe Sandino Moses in exchange for their influence on North Charleston City Council and their support of the rezoning of the Baker Hospital site. Hicks has agreed to plead guilty to two counts of conspiracy to commit bribery with respect to programs receiving federal funds and honest services wire fraud; bribery with respect to programs receiving federal funds, and honest services wire fraud. Hicks has agreed to cooperate fully with federal, state, and local law enforcement agencies. Hicks faces a maximum term of imprisonment of 20 years, a fine of \$250,000, and a term of supervised release of three years.

Hason Tatorian ("Tory") Fields is charged with conspiracy to commit bribery with respect to programs receiving federal funds and honest services wire fraud, bribery with respect to programs receiving federal funds, and honest services wire fraud. The indictment alleges that Fields conspired with Hicks to pay bribes to Sandino Moses. Thereafter, Fields paid Moses two bribes in an attempt to influence him in connection with his official action regarding the rezoning of the Baker Hospital site. Fields faces a maximum term of imprisonment of 20 years, a fine of \$250,000 and a term of supervised release of three years.

Sandino Moses is charged with misprision of a felony. The Information alleges that Moses knew that Fields and others attempted to bribe him and paid him bribes but he failed to disclose that criminal conduct and instead took steps to conceal the bribes by returning the money to Fields. Moses has agreed to plead guilty and to cooperate fully with federal state and local law enforcement agencies. He

faces a maximum term of imprisonment of three years, a fine of \$250,000, and a maximum term of supervised release of one year.

Donavan Laval Moten has agreed to plead guilty to conspiracy to commit bribery with respect to programs receiving federal funds and honest services wire fraud, theft with respect to programs receiving federal funds, bribery with respect to programs receiving federal funds, honest services wire fraud, and money laundering. The information alleges that Moten conspired with Jerome Heyward and Rose Lorenzo to kick back a portion of funds that Moten's nonprofit received from North Charleston to Heyward, who at the time was on North Charleston's City Council. The indictment further alleges that after receiving the money from North Charleston, Moten laundered Heyward's portion through Lorenzo. Moten has agreed to cooperate fully with federal, state, and local enforcement officials. Moten faces a maximum term of imprisonment of 20 years, a fine of \$500,000 and a term of supervised release of three years.

Michelle Stent-Hilton is charged with conspiracy to commit bribery with respect to programs receiving federal funds and honest services wire fraud, theft with respect to programs receiving federal funds, bribery with respect to programs receiving federal funds, honest services wire fraud, and money laundering. The indictment alleges that Stent-Hilton, who is affiliated with a non-profit and served as Jerome Heyward's personal assistant, promised to pay Heyward a portion of money the non-profit received from the city of North Charleston. At the time, Heyward was serving on North Charleston City Council and voted on the grant proposal to distribute funds to non-profits, including Stent-Hilton's. The indictment further alleges that after receiving money from North Charleston, Stent-Hilton laundered Heyward's kick back through Rose Lorenzo. Stent-Hilton faces a maximum term of imprisonment of 20 years, a fine of \$500,000 and a term of supervised release of three years.

Rose Emily Lorenzo is charged with conspiracy to commit bribery with respect to programs receiving federal funds and honest services wire fraud, theft with respect to programs receiving federal funds, bribery with respect to programs receiving federal funds, honest services wire fraud, and money laundering. The indictment alleges that Lorenzo conspired with Jerome Heyward and others to kick back a portion of City of North Charleston grant funds that were awarded to non-profits affiliated with Donovan Moten and Michelle Stent-Hilton to Heyward. The indictment further alleges that Lorenzo agreed to launder the funds by acting as an intermediary who received the funds from Moten and Stent-Hilton, and then wired them to Heyward for the purpose of concealing the true purpose of the transaction. Lorenzo faces a maximum term of imprisonment of 20 years, a fine of \$500,000 and a term of supervised release of three years.

Heyward, Moten, Hicks, and Moses are scheduled to plead guilty before the Honorable Richard M. Gergel on Friday, Feb. 28.

"When elected officials take their oath of office, they make a sacred promise to the people they serve. They pledge to uphold the law, to act with integrity, and to place the public interest above their own," said Acting U.S. Attorney Brook B. Andrews for the District of South Carolina. "Public service should never merely be a job – it is a public trust. The allegations in this case describe a profound betrayal of that trust."

“Public corruption at any level of government cannot be tolerated,” said Steve Jensen Special Agent in Charge of the FBI Columbia Field Office. “Citizens have a right to expect honesty, fairness, and integrity from their leaders. The FBI, in collaboration with our law enforcement partners, is dedicated to aggressively investigating corruption and ensuring those responsible are held accountable.”

“SLED Agents worked hand-in-hand with our federal partners to ensure that justice will be served,” said SLED Chief Mark Keel. “No matter who you are, or what position you hold, you will be held accountable for breaking the law. Elected officials and citizens should be working together to better their community, not exploiting others.”

The case was investigated by the FBI Columbia Field Office and the South Carolina Law Enforcement Division. Assistant U.S. Attorneys Emily Limehouse and Whit Sowards are prosecuting the case.

All charges in the indictment are merely accusations and defendants are presumed innocent unless and until proven guilty beyond a reasonable doubt in a court of law.

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